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TRAY FOR HOLDING A PLURALITY OF FOOD PRODUCTS

Abstract

The present disclosure is directed to a tray for holding a plurality of edible food products therein. The tray may include a top surface having a plurality of compartments extending downwardly therefrom in which a bottom wall of each compartment is generally parallel to the tray top surface. The tray may include at least one receptacle adjacent one of the at least one compartments in which a bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface. The tray may further include a first compartment of the plurality of compartments configured to house a solid food component therein, a second compartment of the plurality of compartments configured to house a non-solid food component therein, and at least the first and second compartments are covered by at least one membrane.

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Background/Summary

FIELD OF THE DISCLOSURE

[0001] The present disclosure relates generally to a tray used in the food packaging industry, and more particularly, to a tray having a plurality of compartments and at least one receptacle in which the plurality of compartments hold solid and non-solid food components therein.

BACKGROUND OF THE DISCLOSURE

[0002] Individual packages holding various food products have long been available to consumers. For individual, one-time use snack packages containing, for example, chips and dip or crackers and jelly or chocolate bars and peanut butter, the container normally includes a compartment housing the solid food product and a separate compartment containing the non-solid food product. In many of these containers, the solid food product, like crackers, are stacked on top of each other in a designated compartment in a way that makes it hard for a user to remove the solid food product from the compartment one by one. This leads to consumer frustration and often one or more of the individual solid food products breaking in the process of being removed from the compartment by the user.

[0003] Furthermore, once a user is able to take one or more of the solid food products out of the compartment and dip the solid food into the non-solid food product—like a dip, peanut butter, a chocolate spread, jelly, among others—the user often acquires an excessive amount of the peanut butter onto the cracker, for example, causing a mess.

[0004] Through ingenuity and hard work, the inventors have developed a tray for holding a plurality of edible food products therein, the tray including a plurality of compartments configured to house solid and non-solid food components and at least one receptacle configured to allow a user to (1) effortlessly remove the solid food product from its designated compartment, and (2) scrape off any excess non-solid food component from the solid food component, in a separate area from that which contains the solid and non-solid food component, thereby allowing the user to enjoy the snack provided with less mess.

BRIEF SUMMARY OF THE DISCLOSURE

[0005] In an embodiment, the invention comprises a tray for holding a plurality of edible food products therein. The tray comprises a top surface having a plurality of compartments extending downwardly therefrom, each compartment comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of each compartment is generally parallel to the tray top surface. The tray further comprises at least one receptacle adjacent one of the at least one compartments, the at least one receptacle comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface. A first compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a solid food component therein, a second compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a non-solid food component therein, and at least the first and second compartments are covered by at least one membrane.

[0006] In an embodiment, a first receptacle is adjacent to the first compartment, and a second receptacle is adjacent the second compartment. In an embodiment, a bottom wall of the first receptacle is angled in the direction of the first compartment and a bottom wall of the second receptacle is angled in the direction of the second compartment. In an embodiment, at least one sidewall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface. In an embodiment, the at least one receptacle includes three sidewalls extending between the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle and the tray top surface.

[0007] In an embodiment, the angle of the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is between 10 degrees and 15 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the at least one sidewall of the at least one receptacle is between 10 degrees and 15 degrees. In an embodiment, a top surface sidewall extends downward from the tray top surface circumscribing the plurality of compartments and the at least

one receptacle. In an embodiment, a flange extends outwardly from the top surface sidewall. In an embodiment, a flange extends outwardly from the tray top surface.

[0008] In an embodiment, the first and the second compartment are separated by a first dividing member of the top surface of the tray. In an embodiment, the second receptacle is separated from the second compartment by a second dividing member of the top surface of the tray, the first receptacle is not separated from the first compartment by a dividing member, and the first receptacle is connected to an upper portion of a sidewall of the first compartment. In an embodiment, the sidewall connecting the first receptacle to the first compartment is configured to curve outwardly. In an embodiment, the curved sidewall of the first compartment allows a user to access the solid food component housed within the first compartment. In an embodiment, the second receptacle is configured to be used as a scraping-off area, and when the solid food component is dipped into the non-solid food component, a user scrapes off the excess non-solid food component on the second receptacle. In an embodiment, the angled bottom wall of the first receptacle allows a user to peel off the at least one membrane from the tray top surface.

[0009] In an embodiment, the invention comprises a tray for holding a plurality of edible food products therein. The tray comprises a top surface having a plurality of compartments extending downwardly therefrom, each compartment comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of each compartment is generally parallel to the tray top surface. The tray further comprises at least one receptacle adjacent one of the at least one compartments, the at least one receptacle comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface. A first compartment of the plurality of compartments is adjacent a first receptacle, and a second compartment of the plurality of compartments is adjacent a second receptacle.

[0010] In an embodiment, the first compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a solid food component therein, the second compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a non-solid food component therein, and at least the first and second compartments are covered by at least one membrane. In an embodiment, a bottom wall of the first receptacle is angled in the direction of the first compartment and a bottom wall of the second receptacle is angled in the direction of the second compartment. In an embodiment, at least one sidewall of the first and the second receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface. In an embodiment, the at least one receptacle includes three sidewalls extending between the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle and the tray top surface.

[0011] In an embodiment, a top surface sidewall extends downward from the tray top surface circumscribing the plurality of compartments and the at least one receptacle. In an embodiment, the first and the second compartment are separated by a first dividing member of the top surface of the tray. In an embodiment, the second receptacle is separated from the second compartment by a second dividing member of the top surface of the tray, the first receptacle is not separated from the first compartment by a dividing member, and the first receptacle is connected to an upper portion of a sidewall of the first compartment.

[0012] In an embodiment, the sidewall connecting the first receptacle to the first compartment is configured to curve outwardly. In an embodiment, the curved sidewall of the first compartment allows a user to access the solid food component housed within the first compartment. In an embodiment, the second receptacle is configured to be used as a scraping-off area, and when the solid food component is dipped into the non-solid food component, a user scrapes off the excess non-solid food component on the second receptacle.

[0013] In an embodiment, the invention comprises a tray for holding a plurality of edible food products therein. The tray comprises a top surface having a plurality of compartments extending downwardly therefrom, each compartment comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of each

compartment is generally parallel to the tray top surface. The tray further comprises at least one receptacle adjacent one of the at least one compartments, the at least one receptacle comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface. The tray further comprises a first compartment of the plurality of compartments is adjacent a first receptacle, a second compartment of the plurality of compartments is adjacent a second receptacle, and the first receptacle is connected to an upper portion of one of the at least one sidewall of the first compartment.

[0014] In an embodiment, the first compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a solid food component therein, the second compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a non-solid food component therein, and at least the first and second compartments are covered by at least one membrane. In an embodiment, a bottom wall of the first receptacle is angled in the direction of the first compartment and a bottom wall of the second receptacle is angled in the direction of the second compartment. In an embodiment, at least one sidewall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface.

[0015] In an embodiment, the at least one receptacle includes three sidewalls extending between the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle and the tray top surface. In an embodiment, the first and the second compartment are separated by a first dividing member of the top surface of the tray, and the second receptacle is separated from the second compartment by a second dividing member of the top surface of the tray. In an embodiment, the sidewall connecting the first receptacle to the first compartment is configured to curve outwardly, and the curved sidewall of the first compartment allows a user to access the solid food component housed within the first compartment. In an embodiment, the second receptacle is configured to be used as a scraping-off area, and when the solid food component is dipped into the non-solid food component, a user scrapes off the excess non-solid food component on the second receptacle. In an embodiment, the angled bottom wall of the first receptacle allows a user to peel off the at least one membrane from the tray top surface.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE SEVERAL VIEWS OF THE DRAWING(S)

[0016] Having thus described the present disclosure in general terms, reference will now be made to the accompanying drawings, which are not necessarily drawn to scale, and wherein:

[0017] FIG. 1 is a top perspective view of a tray having a plurality of compartments and receptacles, the compartments housing edible food products therein, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure;

[0018] FIG. 2 is a top side perspective view of the tray of FIG. 1, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure;

[0019] FIGS. 3-4 are side bottom views of the tray of FIG. 1 illustrating the plurality of compartments and receptacles each having a bottom wall and at least one sidewall, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure; and

[0020] FIG. 5 is a close-up perspective view of a first compartment and a first receptacle in which the first receptacle is connect to the sidewall of the first compartment, in accordance with some embodiments of the present disclosure.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE DISCLOSURE

[0021] While this present disclosure may be embodied in many forms, there is shown in the drawings and will herein be described in detail one or more embodiments, with the understanding that this disclosure is to be considered an exemplification of the principles of the present disclosure and is not intended to limit the disclosure to the illustrated embodiments.

[0022] Generally speaking, the present invention is directed to a tray **10** for holding a plurality of edible food products therein. The tray comprises a bottom surface **11** and a top surface **12**, the top surface **12** having a plurality of compartments extending downwardly therefrom. In an embodiment, each compartment comprises a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, the bottom wall of each compartment is generally parallel to the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, at least one receptacle is positioned adjacent one of the at least one compartments, the at least one receptacle comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface **12**.

[0023] In an embodiment, the tray **10** may have as many compartments as desired, with the bottom wall of each compartment being generally parallel to the tray top surface **12**. In other embodiments, the tray **10** may include as many receptacles as desired, with the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle being angular with respect to the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, while FIGS. **1-5** show the tray **10** as being generally rectangular in shape, the tray **10** may include any shape known in the art. In an embodiment, the shape of the tray **10** may be generally square, rectangular, triangular, circular, ovular, elliptical or any other shape known in the art. Furthermore, while FIGS. **1-5** show the plurality of compartments as being generally rectangular in shape, the compartments may include any shape desired. In an embodiment, the shape of the plurality of compartments may be generally square, rectangular, triangular, circular, ovular or any other shape known in the art. In still other embodiments, the plurality of compartments can each have different compartment shapes.

[0024] In an embodiment, the plurality of compartments may include a first compartment **20** and a second compartment **30**, and the at least one receptacle may include a first receptacle **24** and a second receptacle **34**, as will be explained in greater detail herein. FIG. **1** illustrates the tray **10** having a first compartment **20** and a second compartment **30**. In an embodiment, the first and second compartments **20**, **30** comprise a bottom wall **20a**, **30a** and four sidewalls, as shown in FIGS. **3-4**. In an embodiment, the first and second compartments **20**, **30** include at least one sidewall and, in some embodiments, may include as many sidewalls as desired. Additionally, in some embodiments, the compartments **20**, **30** may include as many bottom walls as desired and, thus, may include multiple bottom walls connected together. As shown, the sidewalls of the compartments **20**, **30** extend between the bottom walls **20a**, **30a** and the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, the bottom walls **20a**, **30a** are generally parallel to the tray top surface **12** and the tray bottom surface **11**. In an embodiment, as shown in FIGS. **4-5** and discussed in greater detail below, the first compartment **20** may include a sidewall **20b** configured to be curved outwardly, i.e., the sidewall **20b** may include an indentation.

[0025] In an embodiment, the first compartment **20** is positioned adjacent a first receptacle **24** and the second compartment **30** is positioned adjacent a second receptacle **34**. In an embodiment, as shown in FIG. **2**, the first and the second compartments **20**, **30** are separated by a first dividing member **14** of the tray **10**. In certain embodiments, the dividing member **14** allows the first and second compartments **20**, **30** to house a plurality of food products therein without the possibility of the plurality of food products mixing. In an embodiment, the second receptacle **34** is separated from the second compartment **30** by a second dividing member **16** of the tray **10**. In an embodiment, the dividing members **14**, **16** each comprise part of the tray top surface **12**. In certain embodiments, the second receptacle **34** may not be separated from the second compartment **30** by a dividing member. In some embodiments, the second receptacle **34** may be connected to an upper portion of a sidewall of the second compartment **30**, and thus not separated from the second compartment **30** by a dividing member.

[0026] In an embodiment, each compartment is designed to house food products. In certain embodiments, the first compartment **20** is configured to house a solid food component **21** therein

(see FIG. 1). In an embodiment, the solid food component **21** may be any edible solid food product sold on the market. In some embodiment, the solid food component **21** may include chocolate bars, chips, crackers, cookies, fruits, vegetables, dried fruits or vegetables, dried meats, among others. In other embodiments, the second compartment **30** is configured to house a non-solid food component **31** therein. In an embodiment, the non-solid food component **31** may be any edible non-solid food product sold on the market. In some embodiment, the non-solid food component **31** may include peanut butter, jelly, melted chocolate, dip, cheese, salsa, among others. In certain embodiments, a third compartment may extend downwardly from the top surface **12** of the tray **10** including a bottom wall and at least one sidewall, wherein the at least one sidewall extends between the bottom wall and the tray top surface **12** with the bottom wall being generally parallel to the tray top surface **12**. In these embodiments, the third compartment may include an additional solid or non-solid food component therein.

[0027] In an embodiment, when manufactured and even after packaged and sealed, the tray receptacles may not include any food components therein. That is, in an embodiment, the tray may be sold, in its final form, with empty receptacles.

[0028] In an embodiment, as shown in FIGS. 2-4, the bottom walls **24a**, **34a** of the first and second receptacles **24**, **34** are generally angular with respect to the tray top surface **12**. Additionally, in certain embodiments, the bottom wall **24a** of the first receptacle **24** is generally angled in the direction of the first compartment **20**, such that the deepest portion of the first receptacle **24** is nearest the first compartment **20**. In an embodiment, the angle of the bottom wall **24a** of the first receptacle **24**, as compared to the tray top surface **12**, is between 5 degrees and 20 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the bottom wall **24a** of the first receptacle **24**, as compared to the tray top surface **12**, is between 10 degrees and 15 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the bottom wall **24a** of the first receptacle **24**, as compared to the tray top surface **12**, is between 12 degrees and 13 degrees. In other embodiments, the bottom wall **34a** of the second receptacle **34** is generally angled in the direction of the second compartment **30**, such that the deepest portion of the second receptacle **34** is nearest the second compartment **30**. In an embodiment, the angle of the bottom wall **34a** of the second receptacle **34**, as compared to the tray top surface **12**, is between 5 degrees and 20 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the bottom wall **34a** of the second receptacle **34**, as compared to the tray top surface **12**, is between 10 degrees and 15 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the bottom wall **34a** of the second receptacle **34**, as compared to the tray top surface **12**, is between 12 degrees and 13 degrees. In yet another embodiment, one or both of the bottom walls **24a**, **34a** of the first and second receptacles **24**, **34** may not be generally angular with respect to the tray top surface **12** and may instead be configured to be linear and parallel with respect to the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, at least one sidewall of the first and second receptacles **24**, **34** may also be configured to be angular with respect to the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, the angle of the at least one sidewall of the first and second receptacles **24**, **34** is between 85 degrees and 105 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the at least one sidewall of the first and second receptacles **24**, **34** is between 90 degrees and 100 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the at least one sidewall of the first and second receptacles **24**, **34** is between 93 degrees and 97 degrees.

[0029] In certain embodiments, the number of sidewalls of the at least one receptacle of the tray **10** may vary in number as desired based on the specific use of the tray **10** and the number of compartments. In certain embodiments, the receptacles **24**, **34** may include four sidewalls and a bottom wall **24a**, **34a** that is generally angular to the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, at least one receptacle may include three sidewalls extending between the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle and the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, the second receptacle **34** may have three sidewalls, including two opposite vertical sidewalls **34b**, **34d** and a third sidewall **34c** disposed between the two opposite sidewalls **34b**, **34d**. In an embodiment, the third sidewall **34c** may be configured to be angular with respect to the top surface **12**, while in other embodiments the third sidewall **34c** may be perpendicular to the top surface **12**. In further embodiments, the sidewall **34b**

and/or the sidewall **34a** may be configured to be angular with respect to the bottom wall **34a**. [0030] In another embodiment, the first receptacle **24** may include only two opposite vertical sidewalls **24b**, **24c** with no third sidewall. In an embodiment, the transition from the top surface **12**, along the bottom wall **24a**, to the sidewall **20b** may be a smooth angular transition. In an embodiment, while the sidewalls and the bottom wall of the first and second receptacles **24**, **34** are configured to be linear in shape, any shape known in the art may be used. In an embodiment, the first receptacle **24** may comprise a thumb or finger hold for the user. In certain embodiments, the at least one receptacle of the tray **10** may include no bottom wall and instead four sidewalls, an opposite two of which are angular (not parallel or perpendicular to the top surface **12**) and meet at an apex **35**. In an embodiment, as shown in FIG. **4**, the second receptacle **34** may include four sidewalls **34a**, **34b**, **34c**, **34d**. In an embodiment, the sidewalls **34a** and **34c** are not parallel or perpendicular to the top surface **12** but rather angular to the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, the angle of the sidewalls **34a** and **34c** is between 5 degrees and 20 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the sidewalls **34a** and **34c** is between 10 degrees and 15 degrees. In an embodiment, the angle of the sidewalls **34a** and **34c** is between 12 degrees and 13 degrees. In certain embodiments, the angle of the sidewalls **34a** and **34c** may create an obtuse triangular receptacle **34**.

[0031] In some embodiments, the first receptacle **24** may be separated from the first compartment **20** by a dividing member. In other embodiments, as shown, the first receptacle **24** is not separated from the first compartment **20** by a dividing member or any other element. In these embodiments, the first receptacle **24** may be connected to an upper portion of one of the sidewalls (such as sidewall **20b**) of the first compartment **20**. In an embodiment, as shown in FIG. **5**, the first receptacle **24** may connect to the first compartment by a depression **22** positioned between the first compartment **20** and the first receptacle **24**. In an embodiment, the depression **22** may be used as a finger insert portion that allows a user to insert a finger or other removal means or tool to assist in removal of the food component housed within the first compartment **20**. In an embodiment, the top of the first and second compartments **20**, **30** may be covered by at least one membrane.

[0032] As shown, in an embodiment, because of the indentation or depression **22**, the sidewall **20b** of the first compartment **20** does not have the same sidewall length as the other sidewalls of the compartment **20**. Thus, in certain embodiments, the sidewall **20b** of the first compartment **20** has a smaller sidewall length than the other sidewalls of the compartment **20**. In an embodiment, the sidewall **20b** of the first compartment **20** connecting the first receptacle **24** to the first compartment **20** may further be configured to curve outwardly (see FIGS. **4-5**), with respect to the internal space of the first compartment **20**. In an embodiment, the curved sidewall **20b** of the first compartment **20** creates a space between the curved sidewall **20b** and the food component **21** housed within the first compartment **20** (see FIG. **1**). In an embodiment, the space created by the curved sidewall **20b** allows a user to access the food component housed within the first compartment **20**. In an embodiment, a finger or fingernail may be inserted into the cavity of the first compartment **20**, adjacent curved sidewall **20b**, to contact the edge of the food component **21** and thereby lift the solid food component **21** from the first compartment **20**, ideally without breaking the solid food component **21**. In an embodiment, one or more other sidewalls of the first compartment **20** may also be configured to curve outwardly. In yet another embodiment, the tray **10** may comprise a third compartment housing a solid food component therein. In these embodiments, one or more sidewalls of the third compartment may be configured to curve outwardly.

[0033] Furthermore, in some embodiments, the first and second compartments **20**, **30** may include an indented portion **26**, **36** within the compartments **20**, **30** on an upper portion of the sidewalls of the compartments **20**, **30**. In an embodiment, the indented portion **26** may be positioned opposite the receptacle **24**. In other embodiments, the indented portion **36** may be positioned opposite the receptacle **34**. In an embodiment, the indented portions **26**, **36** may be continuous around three sidewalls of the peripheral top edge of the compartments **20**, **30**. In an embodiment, the indented portion **26**, **36** includes a shelf. In an embodiment, the diameter from the indented portion **26** to the

opposite sidewall **20b** is greater than that of the lower portion **23** of the sidewall **20b** and the adjacent sidewall. This indented portion may further aid a user in lifting the food components out of the compartments **20**, **30** and/or aid in placing the food components within the compartments **20**, **30** during the packaging process. In an embodiment, the food component may be sized to fit snugly within the lower portion **22**, **23** of the compartments **20**, **30**. Additionally, in an embodiment, the second receptacle **34** is configured to be used as a scraping off area for the non-solid food component **31** housed within the second compartment **30**. In certain embodiments, when the solid food component **21** is dipped into the non-solid food component **31**, a user may scrape off any excess non-solid food component **31** on the sidewalls **34b**, **34c**, **34d** of the second receptacle **34**.

[0034] In an embodiment, a top surface sidewall **17** extends downward from the tray top surface **12** circumscribing the tray **10**. In an embodiment, a flange **18** may extend outwardly from the top surface sidewall **17**, as shown. In other embodiments, a flange may extend outwardly from the tray top surface **12**. In an embodiment, the flange allows for more stability to the tray **10**. In certain embodiments, the tray **10** may be made of rigid or semi rigid material. In some embodiments, the tray **10** is made of a polymeric material, paperboard, or some combination thereof, among other options. The tray may be formed using any method known in the art. In an embodiment, the tray top surface **12** is covered and sealed by at least one membrane after filling with the respective food products. In an embodiment, the tray top surface **12** is covered and sealed by two membranes: one that covers compartment **30** and one that covers compartment **20** and receptacle **24**. In another embodiment, the tray top surface **12** is covered and sealed by two membranes: one that covers compartment **30** and receptacle **34** and one that covers compartment **20** and receptacle **24**. Other combinations are possible. In an embodiment, the peelable membrane is sealed thermally or by an adhesive, to initially seal the compartments and keep the food products within the compartments fresh. In an embodiment, a sleeve may further surround the entire tray **10**. In some embodiments, the at least one membrane and/or the sleeve may contain printing materials thereon and/or may be transparent to allow prospective consumers to view the contents within the compartments.

[0035] In use, a user may remove the at least one membrane that is covering the first and the second compartments **20**, **30**. In an embodiment, because of the indentation **21** between the first receptacle **24** and the first compartment **20**, a user may be able to insert a finger or other removal means or tools to remove the solid food component **21** housed within the first compartment **20**. In addition, because of the curved sidewall **20b** of the first compartment **20**, space is created between the sidewall **20b** of the first compartment **20** and the solid food component **21** therein, further allowing the user to use a finger to lift out the solid food component **21** therein. Once the solid food component **21** is taken out of the compartment **20**, the user may dip the solid food component **21** into the non-solid food component **31** housed within the second compartment **30**. Once dipped, the user may then use the sidewalls **34b**, **34c**, **34d** of the second receptacle **34** to scrape off any excess non-solid food component **31** that the user does not desire to consume at that moment. The invention creates an enjoyable snack for the user with a customizable proportion of solid to non-solid food component.

[0036] Many modifications and other embodiments of the present disclosure set forth herein will come to mind to one skilled in the art to which the present disclosure pertains having the benefit of the teachings presented in the foregoing descriptions and the associated drawings. Therefore, it is to be understood that the present disclosure is not to be limited to the specific embodiments disclosed and that modifications and other embodiments are intended to be included within the scope of the appended claims. Although specific terms are employed herein, they are used in a generic and descriptive sense only and not for purposes of limitation.

Claims

- 1.** A tray for holding a plurality of edible food products therein, the tray comprising: a top surface having a plurality of compartments extending downwardly therefrom, each compartment comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of each compartment is generally parallel to the tray top surface; and at least one receptacle adjacent one of the at least one compartments, the at least one receptacle comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface; wherein a first compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a solid food component therein, wherein a second compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a non-solid food component therein, and wherein at least the first and second compartments are covered by at least one membrane.
- 2.** The tray of claim 1, wherein a first receptacle is adjacent to the first compartment, and wherein a second receptacle is adjacent the second compartment.
- 3.** The tray of claim 2, wherein a bottom wall of the first receptacle is angled in the direction of the first compartment and wherein a bottom wall of the second receptacle is angled in the direction of the second compartment.
- 4.** The tray of claim 1, wherein at least one sidewall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface.
- 5.** The tray of claim 1, wherein the at least one receptacle includes three sidewalls extending between the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle and the tray top surface.
- 6.** The tray of claim 1, wherein the angle of the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is between 10 degrees and 15 degrees.
- 7.** The tray of claim 4, wherein the angle of the at least one sidewall of the at least one receptacle is between 10 degrees and 15 degrees.
- 8.** The tray of claim 1, wherein a top surface sidewall extends downward from the tray top surface circumscribing the plurality of compartments and the at least one receptacle.
- 9.** The tray of claim 8, wherein a flange extends outwardly from the top surface sidewall.
- 10.** The tray of claim 1, wherein a flange extends outwardly from the tray top surface.
- 11.** The tray of claim 1, wherein the first and the second compartment are separated by a first dividing member of the top surface of the tray.
- 12.** The tray of claim 2, wherein the second receptacle is separated from the second compartment by a second dividing member of the top surface of the tray, wherein the first receptacle is not separated from the first compartment by a dividing member, and wherein the first receptacle is connected to an upper portion of a sidewall of the first compartment.
- 13.** The tray of claim 12, wherein the sidewall connecting the first receptacle to the first compartment is configured to curve outwardly.
- 14.** The tray of claim 13, wherein the curved sidewall of the first compartment allows a user to access the solid food component housed within the first compartment.
- 15.** The tray of claim 2, wherein the second receptacle is configured to be used as a scraping-off area, and wherein when the solid food component is dipped into the non-solid food component, a user scrapes off the excess non-solid food component on the second receptacle.
- 16.** The tray of claim 3, wherein the angled bottom wall of the first receptacle allows a user to peel off the at least one membrane from the tray top surface.
- 17.** A tray for holding a plurality of edible food products therein, the tray comprising: a top surface having a plurality of compartments extending downwardly therefrom, each compartment comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of each compartment is generally parallel to the tray top surface; and at least one receptacle adjacent one of the at least one compartments, the at least one receptacle comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall

and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface; wherein a first compartment of the plurality of compartments is adjacent a first receptacle, and wherein a second compartment of the plurality of compartments is adjacent a second receptacle.

18. The tray of claim 17, wherein the first compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a solid food component therein, wherein the second compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a non-solid food component therein, and wherein at least the first and second compartments are covered by at least one membrane.

19. The tray of claim 17, wherein a bottom wall of the first receptacle is angled in the direction of the first compartment and wherein a bottom wall of the second receptacle is angled in the direction of the second compartment.

20. The tray of claim 17, wherein at least one sidewall of the first and the second receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface.

21. The tray of claim 17, wherein the at least one receptacle includes three sidewalls extending between the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle and the tray top surface.

22. The tray of claim 17, wherein a top surface sidewall extends downward from the tray top surface circumscribing the plurality of compartments and the at least one receptacle.

23. The tray of claim 17, wherein the first and the second compartment are separated by a first dividing member of the top surface of the tray.

24. The tray of claim 17, wherein the second receptacle is separated from the second compartment by a second dividing member of the top surface of the tray, wherein the first receptacle is not separated from the first compartment by a dividing member, and wherein the first receptacle is connected to an upper portion of a sidewall of the first compartment.

25. The tray of claim 24, wherein the sidewall connecting the first receptacle to the first compartment is configured to curve outwardly.

26. The tray of claim 25, wherein the curved sidewall of the first compartment allows a user to access the solid food component housed within the first compartment.

27. The tray of claim 17, wherein the second receptacle is configured to be used as a scraping-off area, and wherein when the solid food component is dipped into the non-solid food component, a user scrapes off the excess non-solid food component on the second receptacle.

28. A tray for holding a plurality of edible food products therein, the tray comprising: a top surface having a plurality of compartments extending downwardly therefrom, each compartment comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of each compartment is generally parallel to the tray top surface; and at least one receptacle adjacent one of the at least one compartments, the at least one receptacle comprising a bottom wall and at least one sidewall extending between the bottom wall and the tray top surface, wherein the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface; wherein a first compartment of the plurality of compartments is adjacent a first receptacle, wherein a second compartment of the plurality of compartments is adjacent a second receptacle, and wherein the first receptacle is connected to an upper portion of one of the at least one sidewall of the first compartment.

29. The tray of claim 28, wherein the first compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a solid food component therein, wherein the second compartment of the plurality of compartments is configured to house a non-solid food component therein, and wherein at least the first and second compartments are covered by at least one membrane.

30. The tray of claim 28, wherein a bottom wall of the first receptacle is angled in the direction of the first compartment and wherein a bottom wall of the second receptacle is angled in the direction of the second compartment.

31. The tray of claim 28, wherein at least one sidewall of the at least one receptacle is angular with respect to the tray top surface.

- 32.** The tray of claim 28, wherein the at least one receptacle includes three sidewalls extending between the bottom wall of the at least one receptacle and the tray top surface.
- 33.** The tray of claim 28, wherein the first and the second compartment are separated by a first dividing member of the top surface of the tray, and wherein the second receptacle is separated from the second compartment by a second dividing member of the top surface of the tray.
- 34.** The tray of claim 28, wherein the sidewall connecting the first receptacle to the first compartment is configured to curve outwardly, and wherein the curved sidewall of the first compartment allows a user to access the solid food component housed within the first compartment.
- 35.** The tray of claim 28, wherein the second receptacle is configured to be used as a scraping-off area, and wherein when the solid food component is dipped into the non-solid food component, a user scrapes off the excess non-solid food component on the second receptacle.
- 36.** The tray of claim 28, wherein the angled bottom wall of the first receptacle allows a user to peel off the at least one membrane from the tray top surface.
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